

Getting Started with Stata

Workshop 1 — Stata Onboarding / Working with Data

No statistics background assumed. No prior Stata assumed.

Get the files: tinyurl.com/ndpop-stata-1

green **Code** button → **Download ZIP** → unzip it → double-click `start_here.do`

A recipe is an analysis

Ingredients

Data

Instructions

Code

Cooking

Running it

Something worth eating

Tables and figures

- Think of a dish you can make. How do you make it?
- What would you have to write down for **someone else** to make it?
- **And what if you are not in the room to explain?**

That last question is the whole workshop. Everything today is about leaving instructions good enough to work without you standing next to them — including for you, in six months.

The general data workflow



- **Inspect and clean are a loop**, not two steps in a row. Solid boxes: that is this room, Blocks 2 and 3.
- **Dashed boxes are the file you take home.** Block 4 goes all the way to a figure — on your own, afterwards.
- **Grey is the one nobody does today.** Someone made these extracts before you arrived, and importing a file someone else produced is not collecting.

COLLECT is the only stage nobody does today. Everything else is here — and all of it is the part that is the same *regardless* of what you are asking, which is why it is worth learning first.

Block 2 — First look at Stata

COLLECT

INSPECT

CLEAN

ANALYZE

REPORT

- **Look before you touch.** Nothing in this block changes the data, and nothing in it needs saving.
- You will make Stata fail on purpose, twice. **Errors are normal. Read them.**
- The block ends by turning everything you typed into a file you could run again.

What is one row?

Worksheet, Block 2

The shape of every Stata command

```
[prefix:]  command  [varlist]  [= exp]  [if]  [in]  [weight]  
           [using filename]  [, options]
```

Square brackets mean optional. **Only *command* is compulsory**, and almost everything you will ever type is a variation on that one line — which is why the six describe variants in Block 2 were worth running one at a time.

Met it already *command* · *varlist* · *if* · *in* · *options*

Coming up = *exp* in Block 3 · *using filename* in Block 4 · *prefix* at 3.8

Rarely, for now *weight*

You have already met most of it without being told. Block 3 is where you start writing it yourself.

Block 3 — Your first Stata project



- **The loop, for real.** Look, change, look again — and this time write it down as you go, in a do-file rather than the command window.
- Stata has a command that **halts the file** the moment a claim you have made about the data turns out to be false. You are about to make it fail on purpose.
- **A summary table you skim past is easy to ignore. A file that refuses to continue is not.**
- From here you write the syntax yourself. The sheet tells you what to do and names the command; it does not spell it.

Worksheet, Block 3

Block 4 — First output from raw input



- **This one is yours to take home.** A raw Google Trends export — Notre Dame, MIT, Clemson, monthly, 2004 to 2026 — carried all the way to the figure on the screen.
- It is written to be followed from cold. Nothing in it depends on anything you did today.
- Every task names the **help file**, not the command. That is the real skill: nobody memorises Stata.

In Block 2, one row was one state. What is one row *here*?

Getting unstuck, in order

1. **Stata's own help.** The full manuals are already installed on this machine.
2. **Search by keyword**, when you do not know the command's name yet.
3. **The internet** — and paste the *exact* error text, error number and all. Somebody has had your problem.
4. **A person.** Sooner than you think.

An error message is not a scolding. It is the most specific help you will get all day, and it is free.

Help from actual people

ND Pop Stata Helpdesk

Drop in, no appointment. **Mon–Thu 5–7pm, 4020D Jenkins Nanovic Halls.** Bring your laptop.

Navari Family Center for Digital Scholarship

Hesburgh Library, 2nd floor NE corner. Data analysis, visualisation, GIS, text mining.

AI chatbots — one rule

Useful for finding a command name or decoding an error. They also invent options that do not exist, fluently and confidently. **Never run a command from a chatbot until you understand it independently.**

Before we part

These are shared machines

The workshop files are safe — you can download them again any time. **The files you wrote today are not.** USB stick, email, or cloud drive, before you log out.

- Everything is on github.com/cassandramerritt/ndpop-stata-workshops, permanently.
- **Block 4 is waiting for you**, with every answer in a second file beside it.
- **Workshop 2 — Data Wrangling.** Collapse, append, merge, reshape. Building the dataset an analysis actually needs, out of the files you were handed.

What is one row?